Your Own Chatbot

The COSC 1210 capstone: one project instead of the weekly home assignments. You build a chatbot on the ELIZA engine and present it in class.

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Meet SAGE, a study buddy

→ **Switch to terminal · `python eliza.py`**

```
SAGE: Hi, I am SAGE, your study buddy. What are you working on?
You: I'm nervous about the quiz.
SAGE: What part of it makes you nervous?
You: I don't understand regular expressions.
SAGE: Which part of regular expressions is unclear?
You: THIS IS NOT WORKING!
SAGE: No need to shout. What happened?
You: bye
SAGE: Good luck. Take a break before the next session.
```

SAGE is ELIZA with a different script. Your project: a bot of your own.

Engine and script

Engine `eliza.py` – Python, given

```python
def respond(sentence, script):
    sentence = normalize(sentence)
    for rule in script["rules"]:
        match = re.search(rule["pattern"],
                          sentence)
        if match is not None:
            ...
```

Script `yourname.yaml` – the persona, yours

```yaml
name: 'SAGE'
greeting: 'Hi, I am SAGE, your study buddy.'
rules:
  - pattern: '\bi don.?t understand (.*)'
    replies:
      - 'Which part of {x} is unclear?'
      - 'Can you explain {x} in one sentence?'
```

Same split as Weizenbaum's ELIZA (1966): one engine, many scripts.

Pick a track

1. **A new persona.** Your own script: a study buddy, a campus guide, a help desk, a cooking coach, a character you invent. Most projects are this track.
2. **A better engine.** A persona with fewer rules, plus a bigger change to the code: memory ("Earlier you said your sister..."), statistics on which rules fire, a bot that remembers your name.
3. **Your own text program.** A text analyzer, a quiz program... only with an approved proposal.

What you hand in

- `eliza.py` runs from the terminal in your virtual environment
- `yourname.yaml`: at least 12 rules with 2 replies each; 4 use `{x}`, 3 use `\b`; your own greeting, goodbye, fallback, reflections
- one function of your own in `eliza.py`, with a docstring and 2 doctests (in a pair: one each)
- `conversation.txt`: 15 test lines that fire every rule, and its output `transcript.txt`
- AI-use statement at the top of `eliza.py`: tool, what for, what you checked

Milestones

Milestone	Due	Points
Proposal	Mon 11/16, 2:00 pm	3
Prototype	Mon 11/23, 2:00 pm	7
Final code	Tue 12/01, 11:59 pm	10
Presentation	in class, 12/02 or 12/04	10
Total		30

Proposal: what your bot is for, five sample exchanges, who writes what.
Prototype: the program runs, at least 6 of your own rules work.
Final code: no late submission – the presentations start the next day.

The presentation: 6 minutes + 3 for questions

1. What your bot is for
2. Live demo: your test lines, then two or three lines from the audience
3. One rule: its pattern, and why it is above or below another rule
4. One function, explained by the person who wrote it
5. One thing that went wrong and how you fixed it
6. How you used AI and what you checked

Alone or in a pair

- A pair is recommended: two of you, one bot, one presentation
- Each of you writes at least one function and explains it
- Both of you speak in the presentation
- Rules for every persona: no real people, no medical, legal or crisis advice, replies you would show in class

What you need, and where it comes from

You need	You get it
Python and a virtual environment	the setup assignment, due this week
patterns: `re.search`, groups, `\b`	the next lecture
lists, dictionaries	the next two weeks
YAML files, the starter code	after dictionaries

The setup assignment is the first step of the capstone: the bot runs in your venv.

Next steps

1. Finish the Python setup assignment
2. Find a partner, or decide to work alone
3. Think of a persona: who would talk to your bot, and about what?
4. Write five sample exchanges – that is most of your proposal

The full brief is on Canvas.